

Specific processing correlates associated to Experiencer role.

Introduction

Experiencer thematic role designates the participant of an event that experiences the mental state denoted by the verb [1]. This role appears in [3,4]:

Psych verbs		Perceptual verbs
Cause-Experiencer	Experiencer-Theme	Experiencer-Theme
i.e. <i>frighten</i>	i.e. <i>love</i>	i.e. <i>observe</i>

Dowty's [2] Proto-Roles theory: **Experiencer** role fits in **Proto-Agent** category due to **sentience** entailment; it is less prototypical than Agent because Experiencer only possesses one entailment.

Psycholinguistic evidence shows that Agents have different processing correlates than Themes [5]. Experiencer processing has not been investigated yet.

Has the Experiencer thematic role a specific processing pattern?

Methods

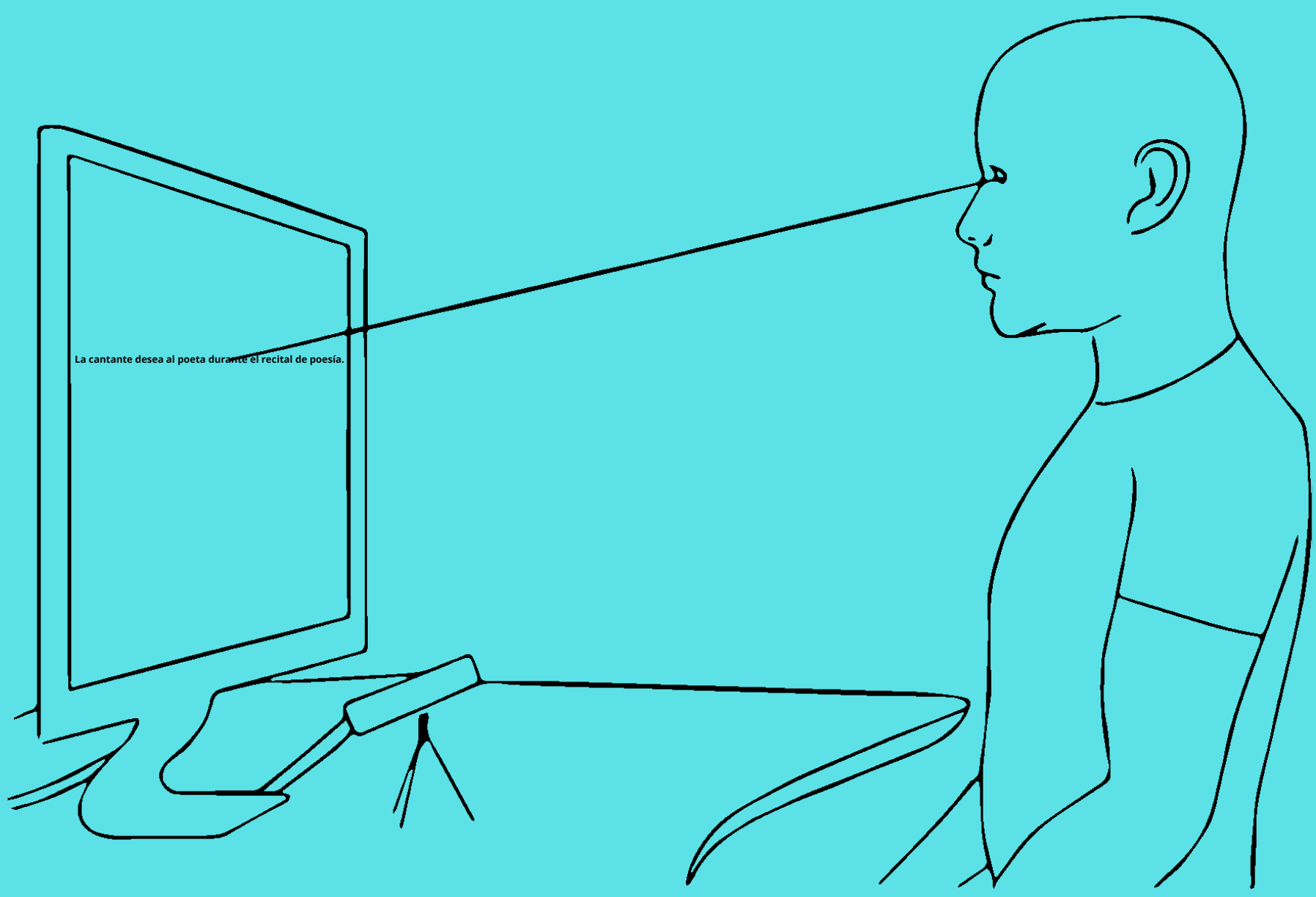
Eye-tracking

48 Spanish native speakers (M=21 years).
Reading task with some comprehension questions.
20 verbs per condition controlled by length and frequency.
40 experimental items and 80 fillers. Acceptability task was made to control naturalness of sentences.
2x2 repeated measures design:

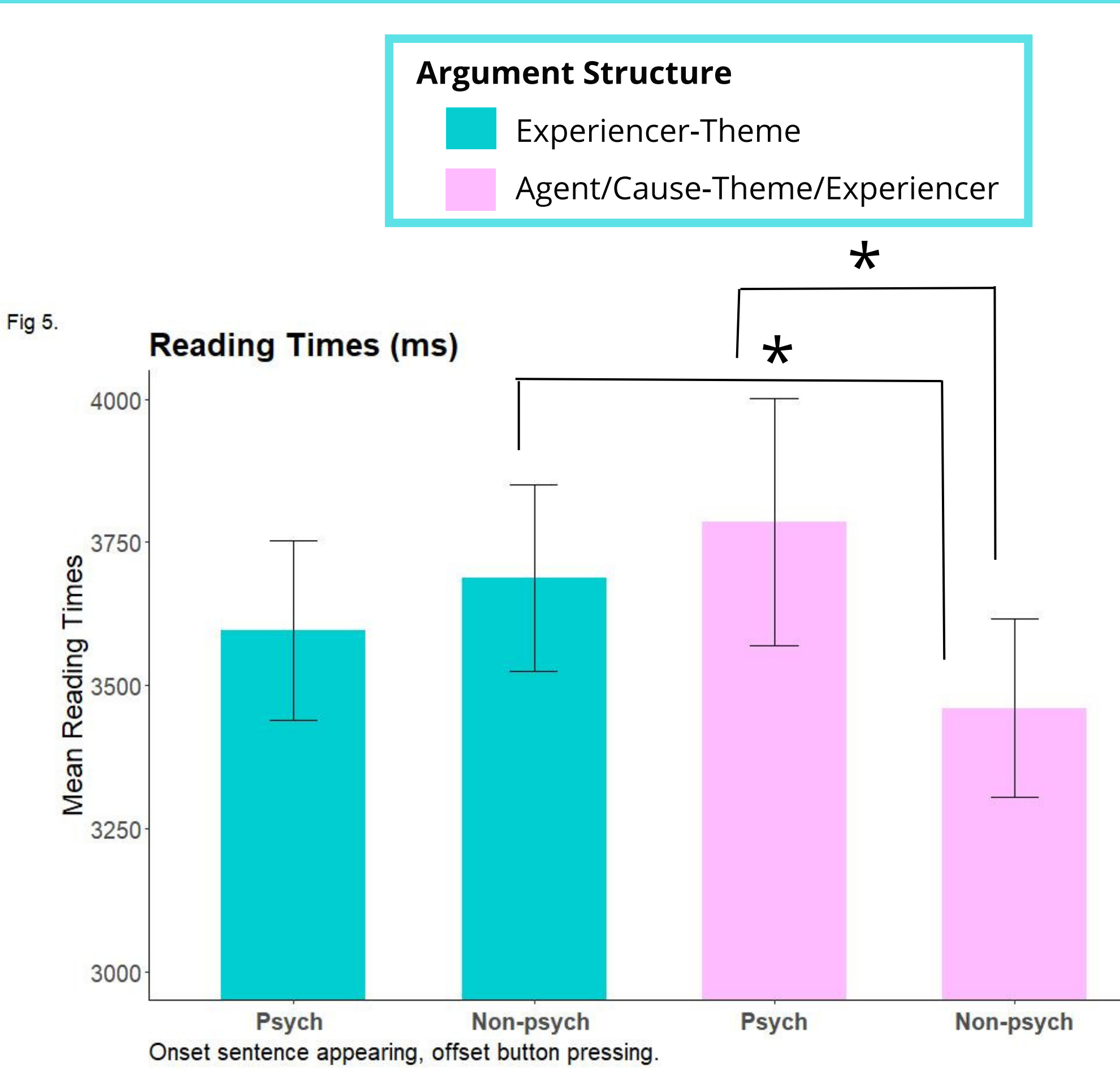
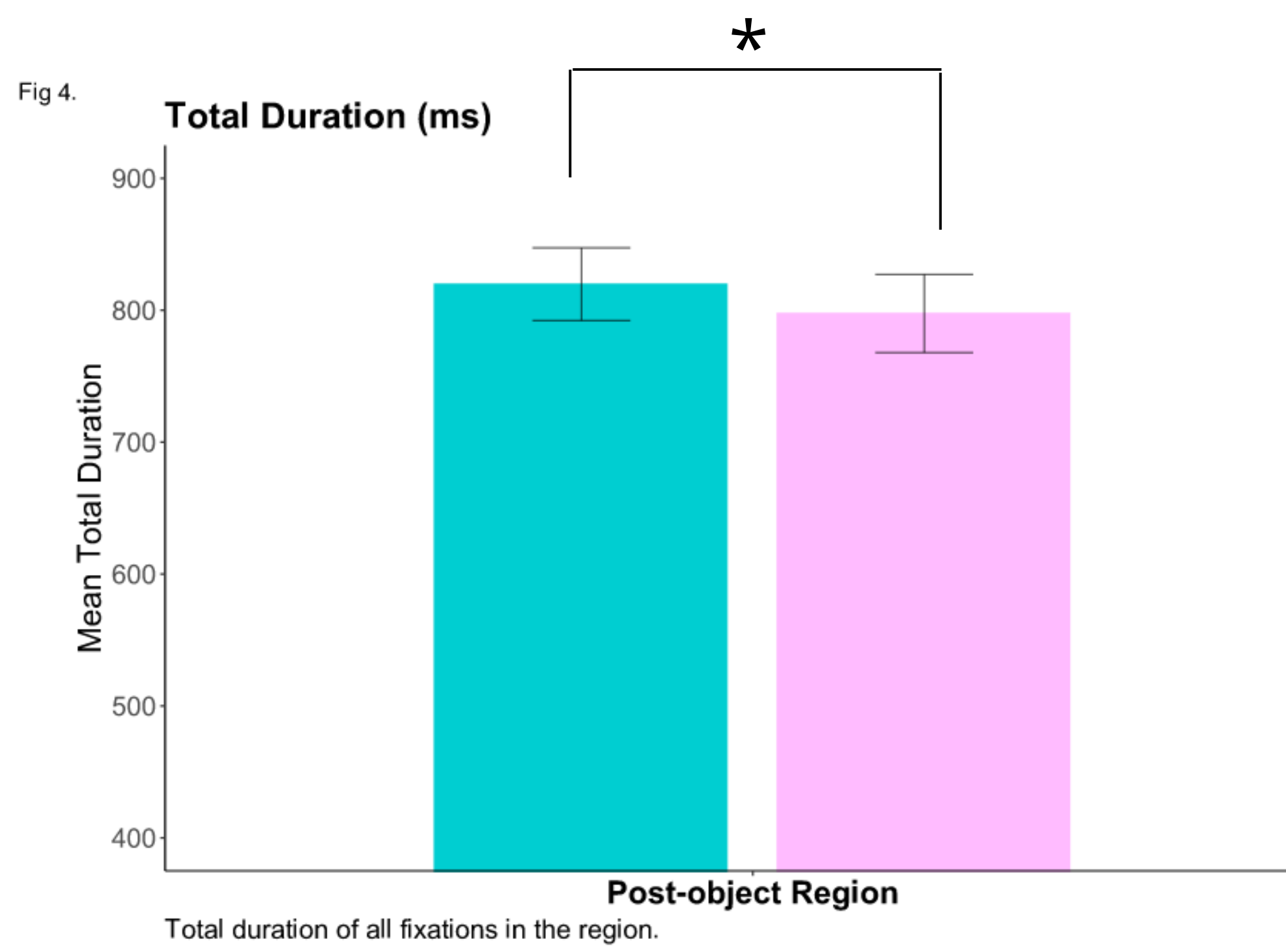
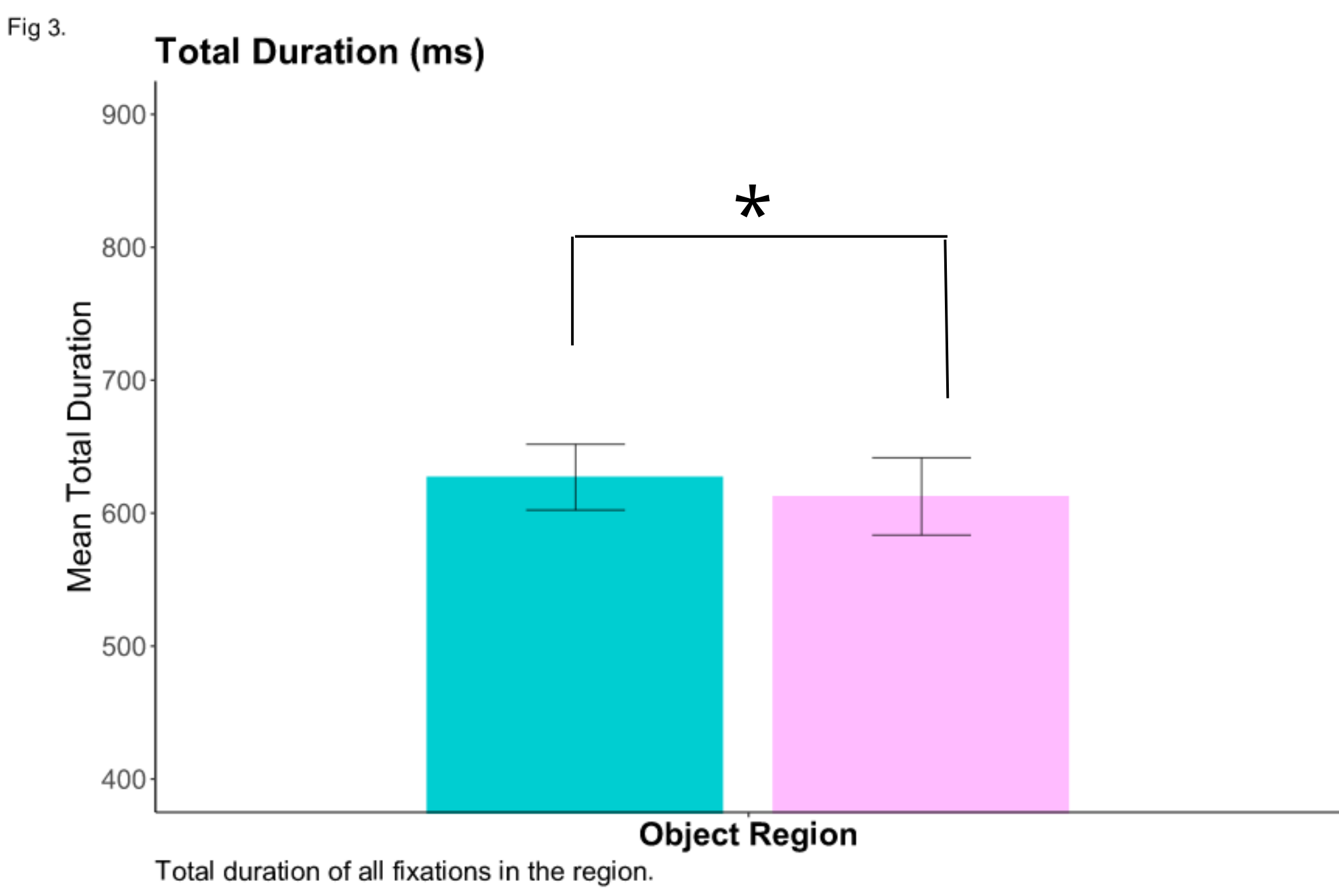
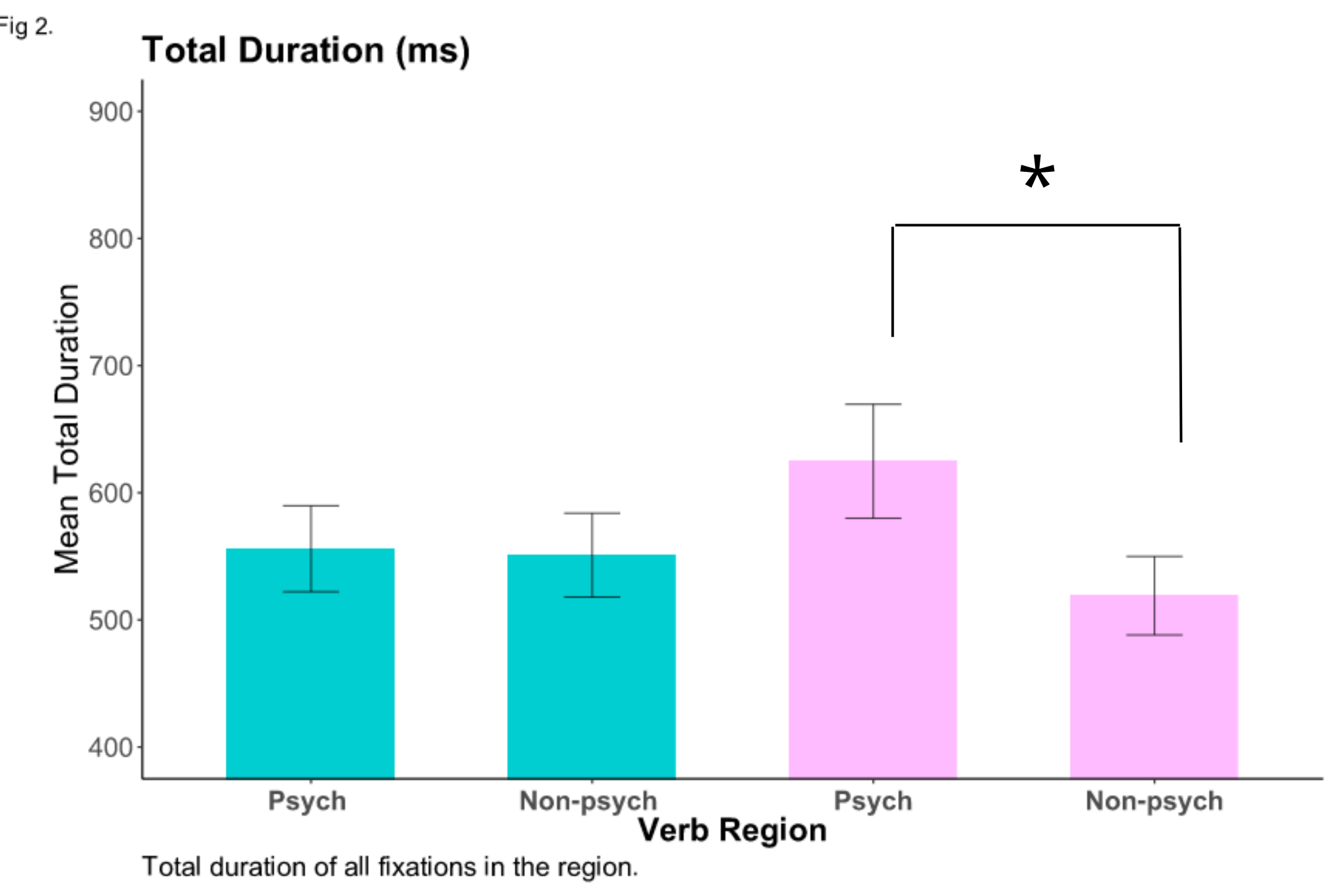
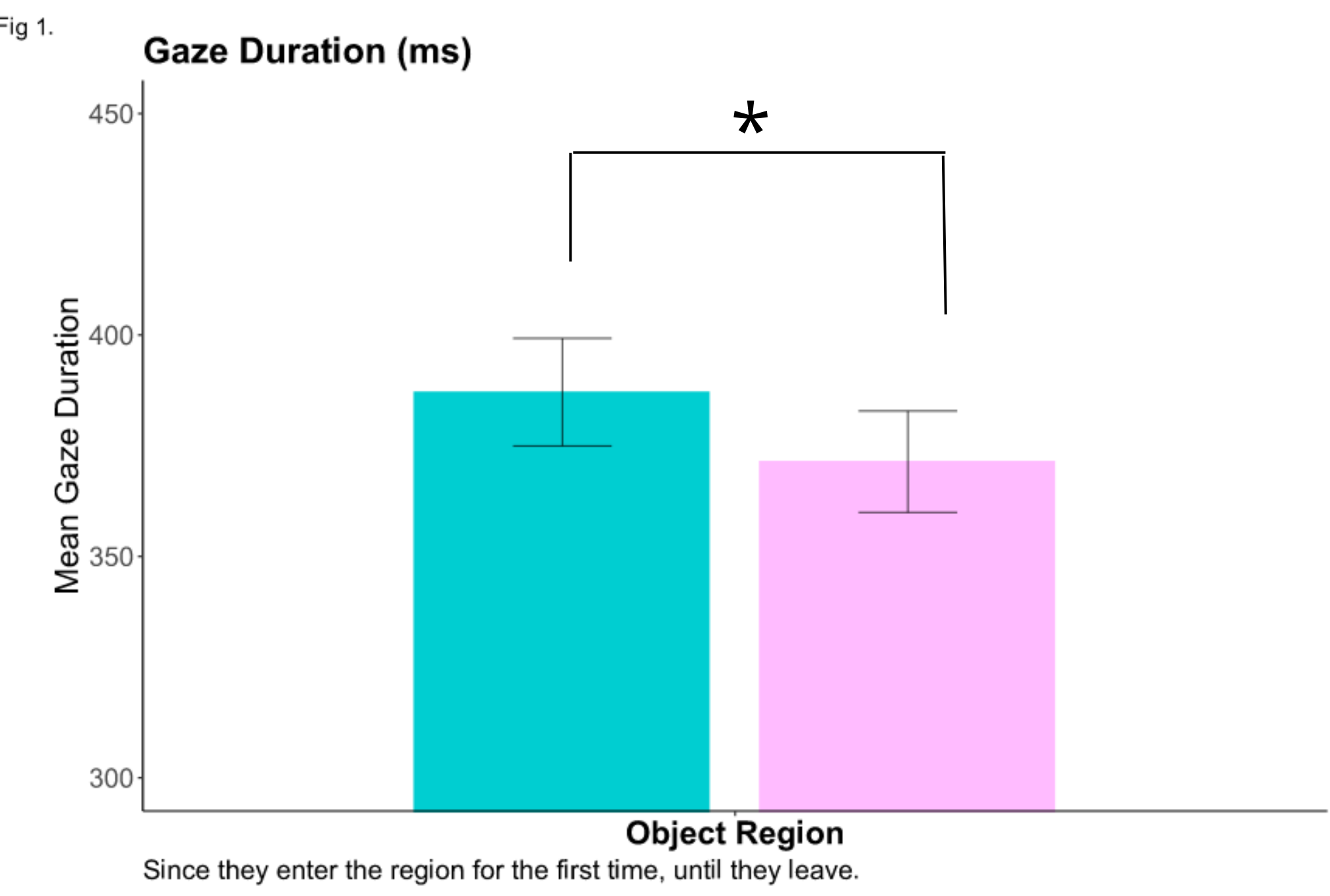
Verb Type (Psych vs. Non-psych)
Argument Structure (Experiencer-Theme vs. Agent/Cause-Theme/Experiencer)

Materials

Verb Type	Argument Structure	Subject Region	Verb Region	Object Region	Post-Object Region	Last-word Region
Psych	Experiencer-Theme	La cantante	<i>desea</i>	al poeta	durante el recital de	poesía.
Psych	Cause-Experiencer	La cantante	<i>enamora</i>	al poeta	durante el recital de	poesía.
Non-psych	Experiencer-Theme	La cantante	<i>contempla</i>	al poeta	durante el recital de	poesía.
Non-psych	Agent-Theme	La cantante	<i>abadona</i>	al poeta	durante el recital de	poesía.



Results



Discussion and Conclusion

Experiencer role involves increased processing load. It is not a prototypical Agent [2].

Experiencer-Theme structures show larger processing cost than argument structures with Agent/Cause (fig. 1, 3, 4).

Cause-Experiencer structures have two arguments that are candidates to be Proto-Agent, increasing difficulty to process compared to prototypical Agent-Theme structures (fig. 2 and 5).

We conclude that **Experiencer role has specific processing correlates modulated by the other participant of the argument structure.**

References

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- [2] Dowty, D. (1991). Thematic proto-roles and argument selection. Language, 67(3), 547–619.
- [3] Levin, B. (1993). English Verb Classes and Alternations: A Preliminary Investigation. University of Chicago Press.
- [4] Pesetsky, D. M. (1996). Zero Syntax: Experiencers and Cascades. MIT Press.
- [5] Rissman, L., & Majid, A. (2019). Thematic roles: Core knowledge or linguistic construct? Psychonomic Bulletin & Review, 26(6), 1850–1869.

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Eye-tracking the Experiencer Thematic Role

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